

PRACTICAL SKILLS FOR PHARMACISTS

LISTENING AND EMPATHIC RESPONDING

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Introduction

- In order to have an interaction, we must be able to act as senders and receivers of messages.
- In order to do this, we must develop certain skills.
- They include listening, responding, phrasing questions, and assertiveness.

Listening

- People are better senders of information than receivers of information
- An equally critical part of the communication process, and perhaps the most difficult to learn, is the ability to be a good listener.
- As the receiver of messages, your ability to listen well influences the accuracy with which you can decode messages in a way that is congruent with patients' intended messages.

Cont...

- Listening, like communication in general, does not come naturally to most people.
- ❖ Recommendations in this regard
 - Stop talking
 - Remove distractions
 - Good eye contact
 - React to ideas (not the person)
 - Listen to how something is said (tone, voice, rate,...)
 - Read nonverbal messages

Types of Responses

1. Empathic Response
2. Judging Response
3. Advising Response
4. Placating or Reassuring Response
5. Generalizing Response
6. Probing Response
7. Distracting Response
8. Understanding Response

Empathic Responding

Empathy

- Many of the messages' patients send to you involve the way they feel about their illnesses or life situations.
- If you can communicate back to a patient that you understand these feelings, then a caring, trusting relationship can be established.
- Communicating that you understand another person's feelings is a powerful way of establishing rapport and is a necessary ingredient in any helping relationship.

Cont...

- Empathy conveys understanding in a caring, accepting, nonjudgmental way.
- An empathic response goes beyond an understanding response to address the feelings that underlie a statement.
- This type of response demonstrates not only that you heard and understood what the person said but also that you recognize the emotions.
- By recognizing and responding to the feelings the person has, you are demonstrating true listening and also caring.

Cont...

- It is important to note that empathy is difficult, if not impossible, to fake.
- People can easily see through a false attempt at empathy and are likely to respond negatively to it.
- Unless you are genuine in your willingness to understand and relate to another person, empathy will be difficult to master.
- Another essential condition is respect for and acceptance of the sender as an autonomous, worthwhile person.
- If you convey an ongoing positive feeling for people, they may be more open with you since they do not fear being judged.

Cont...

- One of the biggest blocks to effective communication is our tendency to judge each other.
- If we think that another will judge us negatively, we feel less willing to reveal ourselves.
- Acceptance and warmth, if it is genuine, will allow people to feel free to be more open in their communication with you.
- In most cases, an empathic response is a beginning to a dialogue.
- It is not the only thing you will say to the patient.
- As you first recognize people's feelings and demonstrate your understanding, people will be reassured of your sincere care about his or her concerns.

Judging Response

- While conveying understanding seems so obviously a part of good communication, several less helpful responses are frequently used in communication with others.
- for example, we tend to judge or evaluate another's feelings.

Examples

- Tell patients in various ways that:
 - ✓ They should not feel discouraged or frustrated.
 - ✓ They should not worry.
 - ✓ They should not question their treatment by other health professionals.

Disadvantages of Judging Response

- Any message from you that indicates you think patients are wrong or bad or that they should not feel the way they do will indicate that it is not safe to confide in you.
- Less helpful type of response.

Advising Response

- It is part of the professional responsibility to give patients advise.
- The presumptuous is to feel that we can offer a quick solution to another personal concerns.

Disadvantages of advising response:

- ☐ The best source of a solution to a problem is within the patient.
- ☐ Relying on others for advice may keep patients dependent because they see others as the source of problem-solving.
- ☐ There are times when patient are not capable of coping with their own feelings or problems.

Placating or Falsely Reassuring response

- Telling a patient who is facing surgery, “Do not worry, I am sure your surgery will turn out just fine”.
- We often use this kind of response to try to get a patient to stop feeling upset or to try to change a patient’s feelings, rather than accepting the feelings as they exist.

❖ Disadvantage

- It may seem to be helpful, but it is really conveying that the person should not feel upset.
- It affects trust

Generalizing Response

- Generalizes what the sender may be feeling.
- This response takes the focus away from the person.
 - ✓ e.g., “I’ve been through the same thing and I’ve survived.”

Disadvantages

- ❑ While it is comforting to know that others have had similar experiences,
 - ✓ This response may take the focus away from the customer's experience and onto your own experience before they have had a chance to talk over their own immediate concerns.
- ❑ It can also lead you to stop listening because you jump to the conclusion that, since you have had an experience similar to the sender's, she is feeling the same way you felt.
 - ✓ This may not, of course, be true.

Quizzing or Probing Response

- ✓ Probing responses are usually in the form of a question designed to elicit additional information.
- ✓ Although probing questions do have their place, a probing response to a situation where a person may be upset is not the best option.
- ✓ Many human problems or emotional concerns are not so easily “solved.”
- ✓ Often, patients want to be able to express their feelings and know that we understand.

Disadvantage

- ✓ Asking questions when the patient has expressed a feeling can take the focus away from the feeling and onto the “content” of the message.
- ✓ It also leads to the expectation that, if enough information is gathered, a solution will be forthcoming.

Distracting Response

- ✓ Many times, we get out of situations to which we do not know how to respond by simply changing the subject.
- ✓ Or to protect ourselves, we cut off patients' communication of feelings.
- ✓ We may try to show them that things are not as bad as they seem.
- ✓ We may direct the communication to subjects we feel comfortable with, such as medication regimens.

Understanding Response

- ❑ This type of response allows a person to convey their understanding of a message.
- ❑ Only in this type of response is there any indication that you truly understand the basis of the sender's concern.
- ❑ By using such a response, you convey understanding without judging as right or wrong, reasonable or unreasonable.
- ❑ A patient who feels discouraged or angry often needs simply: To know that others understand.

Cont...

- ☐ The pharmacists can be helpful by showing concern and understanding.
- ☐ You must be genuine or sincere in the relationship.
- ☐ Respect and acceptance of the patient.
- ☐ Positive feelings for patients and no negative judgment will allow them to be more open in their communication with you.
- ☐ Setting limits in the relationship is ok.

Problems in establishing helping relationships

- ❑ There are countless sources of problems in interpersonal communication between pharmacists & patients.
- ❑ Certain pharmacist attitudes & behaviors are particularly damaging in establishing a helping relationship with the patient.
- ❑ These include stereotyping, depersonalizing, and controlling behaviors.

Stereotyping

- ☐ Negative stereotypes held by health care practitioners that affect the quality of their communication.
- ☐ If you hold certain stereotypes of a patient, you may fail to listen without judgment.
- ☐ We must know what stereotypes we hold & how these may affect the care.
- ☐ We must see the patient as an individual.
- ☐ Only then can we begin to relate to each patient as a person, unique and distinct from all others.

Depersonalizing

- ❑ There are several ways in which communication with a patient can become depersonalized.
- ❑ We may also focus communication on problems and cases.
- ❑ This is a rigid communication format.

Controlling

- Take over or dominate the interaction — making all decisions without involving the patient.
- Intervention to increase levels of patient participation & control in the provider-patient relationship.
- Have yielded positive results that include improved clinical & quality of life outcomes.

HELPING PATIENTS MANAGE THERAPEUTIC REGIMEN

“COMPLIANCE,” “ADHERENCE,” “CONCORDANCE”

- **Compliance:** The extent to which a person’s behavior matches the medical advice given.
- **Adherence:** Persistence in a practice; steady observance, a definition that appropriately conjures up the tenacity that patients need to achieve in sticking to a therapeutic regimen.
 - Lack of patient adherence to medication therapy remains a major health issue.
- **Concordance:** The fact of agreeing or being concordant; agreement, harmony between the prescribers and patients.

Cont...

- Most non-adherence harms patient health, which, in turn, can result in increased emergency room
 - ✓ physician visits,
 - ✓ increased hospitalizations,
 - ✓ decreased productivity in the workplace,
 - ✓ disability, and premature death.
- There are **two** categories of reasons for non-adherence :
 - Inadvertent non-adherence – involves forgetting to take medications at prescribed times;
 - Intentional non-adherence – involves decisions that a patient has made to alter a medication regimen or discontinue drug therapy.

FALSE ASSUMPTIONS ABOUT PATIENT UNDERSTANDING AND MEDICATION ADHERENCE

- Do not assume that:
 - Physicians have already discussed with patients the medications they prescribe.
 - Patients understand all the information given to them.
 - If patients understand what is required, they will be able to take the medication correctly.
- When patients do not take their medications correctly, it is because they....” don’t care”; “aren’t motivated”; or “can’t remember”.
- Once patients start taking medications correctly, they will continue to do so consistently in the future.

TECHNIQUES TO IMPROVE PATIENT UNDERSTANDING

- Emphasize key points e.g. “This is important...”
- Give reasons for the advice.
- Give definite, concrete, explicit instructions.
- Supplement the spoken word with written instructions.
- Finally, end the encounter by allowing patients to provide feedback about what they learned.

Pharmacists may meet physicians to:

- Inform them of new service offerings and your desire to work together to benefit patients
- Encourage physicians to discuss what services would assist them in their practice
- Discuss changes that are taking place in pharmacy in general that could lead to better care for patients
- Update them on new drug developments within a specialty area or in general.

Specific therapy related reasons for calling physicians

- Untreated conditions
- Improper drug selection
- Dosage too high
- Sub therapeutic dosage
- Adverse Drug Reactions (ADRs)
- Drug Information System (DIS)
- Unnecessary drug therapy
- Compliance problems
- Inability to read or interpret a prescription order
- Request to change a product b/c of stock out
- Refill authorization
- Request for additional information about the patient

Preparation Before Calling

- Have the necessary facts ready, including your recommendations and rationales
- Have a literature citation (References) ready
- Know what you are talking about
- Get sufficient information from the patient
- Always have alternative recommendations ready in case your initial recommendation is not accepted.

Thank you !!